Between 1890 and 1910, there was a significant increase in secular schools and a concurrent decline of monastic institutions throughout Burma. This trend was especially relevant in urban areas. One side effect of this situation was that monastic education was forced into rural areas. The ultimate effect of this situation was the creation of economic, cultural, and intellectual divisions between British-educated colonial elites and Buddhist traditionalists. Ultimately, the influence of institutional Buddhism would suffer.

A major turning point in the struggle against colonial control over education came in 1916 with the emergence of the Young Men's Buddhist Association (YMBA). The purpose of the organization was to promote the reintroduction of Buddhist and Burmese subjects into the educational curriculum. The YMBA modeled itself after the Young Men's Christian Association, adopting the structure and strategies of the organization to strengthen the Buddhism in Burma.

Several monks took on key leadership roles in the struggle. The rise of U Ottama, a monk who had traveled extensively in Asia, the Middle East, and Europe, exemplified the role the sangha could play in the anticolonial struggle. His sermons stressed the decline of Buddhism under colonial rule and inspired other monks to join the nationalist movement. It is interesting to note that U Ottama was able to use print media to promote his cause even when he was imprisoned during the 1920s. His importance showed that a monk who had spent extensive time abroad and who could seem to be disconnected from his homeland could be a leading figure in the struggle against the British. As with his role model Gandhi, U Ottama would be imprisoned on three different occasions during his civil disobedience campaigns. His encouragement of economic self-reliance and boycotting helped to steer the nationalist path in a positive direction.

Initially the YMBA was not in direct opposition to colonial policies. The membership of the group consisted of mostly young, British-educated colonial elites. The goal was centered on enhancing the national spirit and emphasizing Burmese culture, literature, and language, as well as Buddhism. The organization did have a more modern and rational perspective on promoting Buddhism. The emergence of the group was a result of the fragmentation of the sangha. Initially the group played a part in providing a welfare function and helped to coordinate the work of several